The CareLeaders TCL

Keynote workbook

Living a Careless Life

What it is really like to grow up in care, and what one adult can change.

Luke Rodgers BEM



Welcome

This workbook is yours

Use it during the keynote to jot down what stays with you, and afterwards to turn it into something you do differently. There are no right answers. Write as much or as little as you like.

The keynote, and this workbook, follow the same three steps.

Story
A real experience of growing up in care.

Theory
The ideas that help explain what happened.

Action
What you will do on Monday.

How to use it

- ☐ **During the keynote:** use the notes boxes. Write down moments, words or phrases that stick.
- ☐ **Afterwards:** work through the activities on your own, with your supervising social worker, or with your team.
- ☐ **Within a week:** make your Monday commitment on page 10, and tell one person about it.
- ☐ **Over the next 12 months:** watch the recording again and come back to your answers.



About Luke

Luke Rodgers BEM grew up in care and went on to lead work across children's services. He is the founder and CEO of The Care Leaders, and works with councils and national government on fostering, leaving care and education. He brings both sides into the room: what care felt like as a child, and what it takes to change a service as a professional.

Part 1 · Story

The story

Luke went into care at 10. By 15 he was living in bed and breakfast accommodation, and at 18 he was living in a caravan. Along the way, some adults made things harder and a few changed everything.

Notes while you listen

What surprised you? What made you laugh? What was hard to hear?

The adults in the story

Someone who helped. What did they do?

Someone who got it wrong. What would have made the difference?

Think of a child you know

Keep one child in mind as you work through this book. You don't need to write their name. Just hold them in your head.

Which part of today's story might be part of their story too?

Part 2 · The system

Small moments, big messages

Children in care notice things adults miss. A meeting held about them without them. A move nobody explained. A worker who remembered their birthday. Each one tells a child whether they are a person or a case.

Moments that build trust	Moments that break it
Being told what is happening and why	*Finding out about a move on the day*

Add your own from the keynote and from your own experience.

Ask yourself

- What would a child in your home or service notice this week?
- Which of your everyday routines could feel like being processed?
- What is one small thing that tells a child they matter?



Words that make a child feel like a case

Much of the language used in care was written for systems, not children. Children hear it, read it in their files and carry it with them. Changing a word is one of the quickest changes any of us can make.

System word	What a child might hear	A word that works better
Placement	*"This is temporary"*	*Home*
Contact	*"I need permission to see my family"*	*Family time*
Absconded	*"I am a criminal"*	
Refused to engage	*"It's my fault"*	
Kicked off		
LAC		

Your turn

Which words do you use most at home, at school or in your service? Which will you change, and what will you say instead?

The child behind the profile

Profiles and referrals often arrive before a child does. When they only list risks and incidents, homes say no, schools hesitate and adults meet the file instead of the child.

A good profile is honest about what a child needs and just as clear about who they are: what they love, what they are good at and what helps on a hard day.

Rewrite it

Each line below is true but tells half the story. Rewrite it so a stranger would want to meet this child.

Before	After
Has a history of aggressive behaviour towards carers.	
Frequently absent from school.	
Struggles to form relationships.	
Can be manipulative.	

Three questions for any profile

1. Would the child recognise themselves in it?
2. Does it say what helps, not only what goes wrong?
3. Would you be happy for them to read it at 18?

Two Timetables

A child in care lives on two timetables at once: the school day, and the meetings, visits and reviews of children's social care. When the two clash, it is the child who pays.

What happens	How it can feel to the child
A review is held in school, in lesson time	*"Everyone now knows I'm in care"*
Called out of class to see a social worker	
Information isn't shared between school and social care	
A move of home means a move of school	

What you can do

Foster and kinship carers

- Ask for meetings out of lesson time
- Get to know the designated teacher
- Ask the child what school knows, and what they want it to know

Professionals

- Check the school timetable before you book
- Share what school needs to know, no more
- Ask the child where they want to meet

One change I will make between home, school and social care:



Part 3 · Theory

What sits behind the behaviour

> **Children come into care not because of what they have done, but because of what has been done to them.**

Behaviour is a message

Behaviour is how children tell us what words can't. When we only respond to the behaviour, we miss the message. Try it with a child you know.

What I see	What it might be telling me
Won't go to bed	*"Night is when bad things happened"*

The window of tolerance

An idea from psychiatrist Dan Siegel. Everyone has a zone where they can think, learn and connect. Stress and trauma can make that window narrow, so children tip into fight, flight or shutting down more quickly. Our job is to help widen the window, not punish the child for leaving it.

PACE

An approach from clinical psychologist Dan Hughes for staying connected with a child when things are hard.

Playfulness · **A**cceptance · **C**uriosity · **E**mpathy

Which one comes most naturally to you? Which is hardest?

Part 3 · Theory

One adult who goes a bit further

Systems matter, but children remember people. The adults who made the difference in Luke's story didn't have special powers. They noticed, they stayed and they went a bit further than they had to.

Going a bit further looks like

- [ ] Remembering what matters to them, without being reminded
- [ ] Explaining decisions, even when the answer is no
- [ ] Repairing after a hard day, rather than starting again cold
- [ ] Speaking up for them in rooms they are not in
- [ ] Staying, when it would be easier to step back

Reflect

Think back to your own childhood. Who was your adult who went a bit further? What did they do?

Who is the child that needs you to be that adult right now?



Part 4 · Action

What I will do on Monday

Pick one thing. Make it small enough to start this week and clear enough that someone could see you doing it.

My commitment

On Monday, I will…

A child will notice because…

I will tell this person, so they can ask me how it's going:

Questions to take back

For your support group, team meeting or supervision.

1. What would a child in our care say we do well, and what would they say we miss?
2. Which words and habits make children feel like a case here?
3. When did we last change something because a child told us to?
4. Who is going a bit further, and how do we back them?



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Keep going

Watch it again

You have access to the recording of this keynote for 12 months. We will email you the link as soon as it is ready, so look out for an email from The Care Leaders.

More from The Care Leaders

We work with councils, fostering services and schools on training, consultancy and programmes, all built on lived and professional experience.

Find out more at **thecareleaders.com**
Questions? Email **hello@thecareleaders.com**

Notes

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